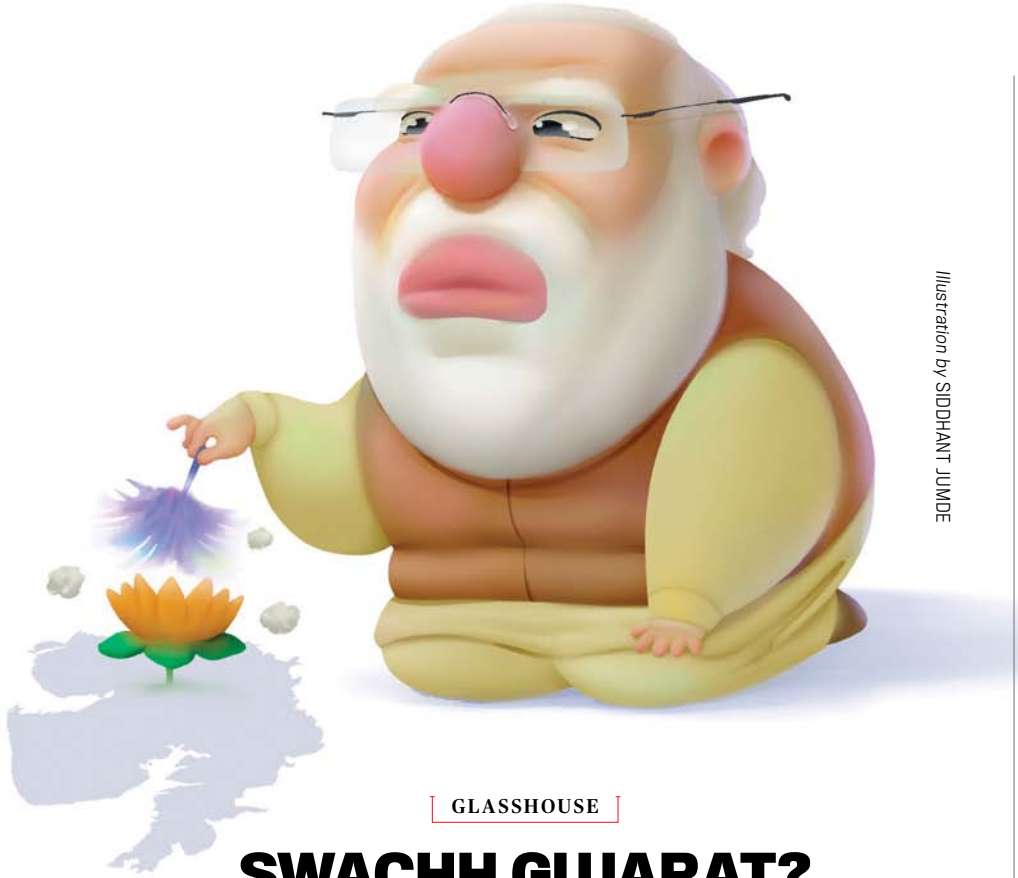


Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

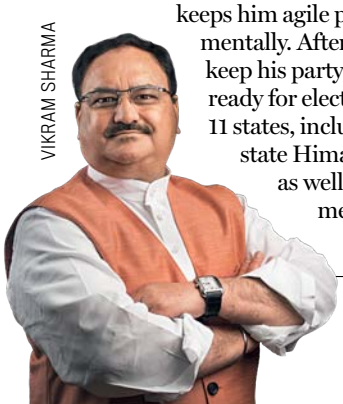
GLASSHOUSE

SWACHH GUJARAT?

Prime Minister Narendra Modi is in no mood to leave any flank exposed for the Opposition to attack the BJP or its government in Gujarat in the run-up to the assembly election later this year. First, the prime minister's office ordered Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel to remove his personal assistant Dhrumil Patel, who was charged with corruption. Then, state BJP president C.R. Patil was asked to sack his personal assistant Sudhanshu Mehta after he was alleged to be high handed towards bureaucrats. The PMO's action has stunned Patil, who was perceived as the PM's blue-eyed boy. The message is clear. No one gets to spoil the game where the stakes are so high.

Going Swimmingly

To keep pace with the demanding job of running the world's largest political party, BJP president **Jagat Prakash Nadda** has turned to what he calls his first love—swimming. When in Delhi, Nadda does 10 laps in the Olympic-sized pool at the Constitution Club. He has also managed to shed some extra weight. An erstwhile national swimmer, Nadda says swimming keeps him agile physically and mentally. After all, he has to keep his party's foot-soldiers ready for election battles in 11 states, including home state Himachal Pradesh, as well as the parliamentary election in 2024.



VIKRAM SHARMA

SHADOW BOXING



PTI

Just before the two-day national executive meeting of all seven wings of the BJP ended in Patna last week, party workers were sent to spend 48 hours in Bihar's 200 assembly constituencies. Perhaps the party wants to reduce its dependency on ally Janata Dal (United), which won only 43 of Bihar's 243 seats in 2020. In public, though, the BJP, or its national general secretary Arun Singh, spout coalition dharma and say they'll contest the together. JD(U) is taking no chances—national president **Lalan Singh** was heard talking about fortifying the party in all 243 seats.

PTI



RATTING ON RAUT

It seems his trusted lieutenants did **Sanjay Raut** in. Pravin Raut and Swapna Patkar blew the whistle on the Shiv Sena MP, which led to the Enforcement Directorate arresting him on August 1 on money-laundering charges. The source of this rumour lies in an audio clip, purportedly a conversation between Sanjay Raut and Patkar, which went viral two days ago. In the clip, Raut is heard abusing Patkar and asking her to return documents pertaining to some properties. In their statements to the ED, Pravin and Patkar provide a list of benami properties Raut allegedly bought. That's instant revenge.



Boss Lady

Former West Bengal minister **Partha Chatterjee**, currently in ED custody, created a ruckus over the food served to him. He wanted rice, mutton and fritters against medical advice. Exasperated, the ED officers sought the help of who else but Arpita Mukherjee, the minister's aide who has also been arrested by the agency. Their conversation seems to have had some effect, as Chatterjee was seen eating oatmeal, roti and sabzi the next day. Highly amused ED officers are now in no doubt as to who the real boss is.

–Kaushik Deka *with Kiran D. Tare, Anilesh S. Mahajan, Amitabh Srivastava and Romita Datta*